Imaginary Mambo

By Margarita Engle

(Pg 97+) I sort of know how to dance, so moves aren't
the challenge that scares me.
It's that partner thing -- waiting to be chosen, standing
alone on the sidelines
with my nervous mind and nerdy glasses.
I've seen enough PG-13 movies to know
that contact lenses, cool clothes, a sassy attitude, and
clipped-short blond hair always work like magic,
attracting the perfect no-losers-allowed
hot football player who somehow boasts both muscles
and brains.
Well, guess what -- I'm not blond, my idea of ***fotbol*** is
soccer,
and I can't actually dance
even half as well as the rest of my family.
My parents and never-nervous party-girl ***primas***/cousins
were all made on the dance-crazy island of Cuba,
while I was born here,

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far from all those legendary drummers who pound out
exhilarating beats on every street corner
in La Habana.
Whenever I have to perform my own shy sort-of-dancy
thing
at family gatherings-birthdays, ***quinceaneras,*** and
wedding receptions
I'm never as relaxed as when I'm alone
in front of a mirror, with nothing but music,
my heartbeat,
and any one of a thousand imaginary boys I know how to
invent.
They're all experts, smart but cute too, and most
importantly, easy to follow
as they lead, spinning me all over
our imaginary dance floor.
If only one of those boys existed!
I'd take him to next week's dreaded
dreadful
deadline-looming
first-in-my-lifetime
Middle School Mixer.

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INTRODUCTION

Margarita Engle's mother is from Cuba and her father is from California. As a child she traveled back and forth to the island, moving seamlessly between two cultures and languages. But beginning in 1963, American travelers were prohibited from traveling to the island. Hostility between the two countries was like a wall in the ocean; creating, as she described it, "a monstrous before and after" in her life. It is her hope that through poetry we can experience a shared empathy – an empathy which can lead to compassion across cultures. And that we can begin to search for and find our similarities rather than our differences.

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One week to go.

Seven days.

One hundred sixty-eight hours.

Ten thousand eighty minutes.

Six hundred four thousand eight hundred endless

agonizing

seconds.

Should I get sick, skip the dance, delay this ordeal until

Winter Formal . . .

or practice with my ***primas***, get lessons from Mami and

Papi,

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maybe steal a boat and row to the island, where

relatives I've never met

will probably be eager to teach me?

But what if they just make fun of me, Cuban-style, by

giving me a nickname that sticks forever, something

clever that means "dorky," "clumsy," "awkward,"

"klutzy," or worst of all: "wannabe."

Cubans and Cuban Americans don't live on the

same planet.

Islanders are born dancing, while here we grow up

watching TV, playing video games, staring at screens,

instead of talking to living, breathing people.

SIX MORE DAYS NOW.

All the overwhelming hours at school

seem impossible, but somehow, I get through the shame of

sitting alone at lunch,

and by the time I go to my aunt's house

in the evening, dancing with my cousins seems so

intimidating that I secretly grow anxious

dizzy

delirious

with fear.

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FIVE DAYS.

I don't even try.

FOUR DAYS.

THREE DAYS.

ONLY TWO MORE DAYS!

The connection to my arms and legs

shuts down, as if someone has switched off all the lights in the entire world.

So I give up, and go to the nursing home

to visit ***Abuela***, because she suffered a stroke not very long ago, and she still needs lots of company to keep her connected to her own arms and legs.

It's in the brain, she explains as we stand side by side in front of a physical therapy clinic mirror while she practices her balancing exercises,

perched on one foot like a flamingo.

It's not easy!

I almost fall.

Try it.

You'll see.

Standing on one leg for more than a few seconds is tricky.

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Abuela needs to learn how to walk again, because the stroke made her brain forget where her feet are located in space,

so she gazes downward as she recites

heel, toe, heel, toe, reminding herself

to do first things first, placing one heel

on the floor, then slowly, carefully lowering those toes.

Afterward, we talk.

The blood clot in her brain took away English,

so we're limited to her first language, but I manage to tell her with ***Espanol*** and gestures just how

worried I am

about the mixer -- a word I translate as ***mezcladora,*** one of those big trucks that stir up wet stuff and gravel

to make hard, gray concrete, like a roadway leading into the unknown.

Ay, como me encantaba bailar! my grandma says with a sigh -- Oh, how dancing enchanted me!

I smile for the first time in days.

It's so easy to be poetic in Spanish.

Her memories seem to float in the air like feathers.

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If only I could feel that weightless and graceful.
No es facil, she says -- It's not easy.
That's the only phrase any Cuban ever uses when faced
with a problem, and even though the words might
sound pessimistic,
it's really so much more hopeful
than claiming that a goal is impossible.
She leans on her walker as we stroll down a hallway,
gazing out windows at a garden with a fountain.
All in the brain.
Not easy, but possible.
You have to practice, ***Abuela*** tells me,
adding, so that ***you*** can teach ***me,*** because I'm sure I've
forgotten.
How could my grandma forget her dance moves? She's
always been able to do the best rumba, conga, or
mambo at any party.
That night, when I go home,
I stand in front of my mirror, wondering how I'll get
through tomorrow.
DANCE DAY!
The gym looks huge, even though it's the same size

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as always.
A table with punch and cookies.
Balloons on strings, drifting toward the ceiling.
Boys stand around in clusters, while girls
jump up and down, wave their arms, and giggle, until
finally, someone I recognize from math class
pulls me into the girl crowd, where I hop
like a three-year-old, suddenly feeling exhilarated,
relieved to discover that no one else knows paired-up-
partner steps,
so there's no pressure to follow a sweaty boy.
Later, when boys start to join in,
my apprehension returns, but at least it's not real horror
anymore,
just his right hand on my waist,
my left hand on his shoulder,
and our other fingers clasped in air.
He's nothing like the thousand boys I've imagined.
Just a shy kid who looks worried as he watches his feet.
We do a little shuffling thing, pretending we know where
we're going until the slow music ends and everyone
goes back to jumping around in time to a fast song, having

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fun, laughing, maybe even secretly imagining

that we're good at this, experts like ***Abuela*** in her memory,

floating

and feathery,

our minds filled

with ***no es facil*** -- it's not easy

possibilities.

ONE WEEK AFTER DANCE DAY.

Okay, so I didn't end up with a boyfriend or dance skills,

but now I hang out with the girl from math class, and at

lunchtime we eat in a crowd of proud nerds,

and starting tomorrow, I plan to practice walking, talking

Spanglish, and dancing to old Cuban music

with my lonely grandma.

The thing about new possibilities is:

It feels so good to share them.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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